CONCEPT OF THE THIRD WORLD

The nomenclature, "*Third World*", definitely calls for a review, particularly the usage of the term in common parlance. Though there is no precise agreement on the meaning of the term yet what constitutes the Third World or why certain countries are categorized as the Third World is a matter of concern for academicians and scholars of IR. It is true that the rapid decolonization of Asia, Africa and Latin America had led to an immense increase in the number of independent states but, at the same time, they were placed in a lower tier of the international hierarchy. Generally, the countries belonging to the Southern hemisphere were classified as belonging to the Third World characterized by underdevelopment and poverty. A wide array of terms have been used over the years to categorize the countries falling under the Third World, and most of the time, the vocabulary used is not neutral. Eric Toussaint[4] draws attention to the variety of terms used to designate the countries belonging to the Third World. In most cases the index of classification is economic. 'Underdeveloped' is the oldest term used and now it has become obsolete as it appeared to be derogatory and carried a reference to the developed countries. Developing countries, developed countries, poor countries, countries of the South, peripheral countries, emerging countries or countries in transition are some of the popular terms used to refer to the Third World countries, presently. Frantz Fanon*, the Algerian writer and author of *The Wretched of the Earth* used the word "third world" at a time when the former colonies of Africa, Asia and Latin America were emerging as newly independent states. To Fanon, these former colonies, struggling for independence, fighting against exploitation of the imperialist powers and neo-colonialism constituted the Third World which lay between the Capitalist and Socialist worlds.

If one tries to look into the origin of the term Third World, it would be found that it was the French scholar, Alfred Sauvy who invented the term and it became very popular during the Cold War. It was used to refer to those countries adopting a position of non-alignment with either of the bloc. Sauvy said, "We readily speak of two opposing